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Sikh Identity And Hindutva Politics



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In their meeting with the members of the National Minorities Commission (Jan 16, 2000), the Rashtriya Seva Sangh (RSS) top brass stated that Sikhism is a separate religion with its own identity, thereby reversing their earlier stance on the subject. This must have come as a temporary relief to most of the Sikhs, who have been deeply agitated by the utterances of RSS leadership. The present rollback of RSS leaders comes in the wake of its attempt to test the waters. The strong protests of most of the Sikhs against celebrating Guru Parab (Guru Govind's birthday) in Hindu temples might have led the RSS top brass to temporarily hold back their agenda. Had they succeeded in selling their 'line' on Sikhism, it would have been a major victory for the *Hindutva* politics in the imposition of its brand of cultural nationalism, which is a modernized version of the culture based on *Brahminical* values.

The attempt to subjugate the Sikh identity by the dominant and elite Hindu stream is nothing new. In the earlier part of the nineteenth century, Swami Dayanand Saraswati of Arya Samaj came down heavily against Sikh Gurus, Sikh scriptures and the Punjabi language, in response to which Bhai Kahan Singh came out with the book, '*Hum Hindu Nahin*'. The current threat to the Sikh identity assumed serious proportions when the RSS chief, K. Sudarshan, while participating in the Rashtriya Sikh Sangat (Sangat) Convention in Amritsar (April 2000) said that Sikhism is a sect of Hinduism while the Khalsa is a part of mainstream Hinduism which was created to protect Hinduism from Mughal tyranny. From that time on, many Sikh organizations undertook protest marches against Sudarshan and pointed out that Sikhism is a religion in its own right and that they will not tolerate the RSS efforts to undermine their separate Sikh identity.

The spokesperson of Dal Khalsa went on to say that, the RSS was trying to impose a centralized monolithic society in India and that they would oppose this hegemonic agenda. Meanwhile, many other Sikh organizations pointed out that the RSS was interfering in the religious, cultural, social and political matters of Sikhs – an act which should be condemned and opposed. In the Lok Sabha, one MP alleged that the RSS was distributing anti-Sikh literature through the Sangat. It was responsible for disturbing the religious harmony in Punjab. This MP also criticized the Ministry of Human Resource Development for giving Rs. 17 crore to the Sangat for RSS propaganda work.

Rashtriya Sikh Sangat has been formed as a progeny of RSS and as a new member of Sangh Parivar. In addition to others, it is being spearheaded by one Shri B.L. Sharma 'Prem' -- a BJP/VHP old hand, who gained notoriety for his famous outpouring that "the rape of nuns is an act of patriotism and nationalism." Since then, he has got himself baptized to Sikhism and is now acting as the Trojan Horse of RSS in the Sikh community. Sikhism is not the only religion which is in the 'swallowing line' of RSS. They are already asserting that Buddha is the tenth *avatar* (reincarnation) of Vishnu. Buddha said nothing new and is a part of the Hindu pantheon.

Till recently, the Vishwa Hindu Parishad (VHP) was against the status of minority being granted to Jainism, because the Parivar regards it as another sect of Hinduism. The ideologues of the Parivar are taking advantage of the fact that all these religions originated from this part of the globe. That they were shrewd in hiding the neo-*Brahminical* nature of current Hinduism and the *Brahminical* oppression of society in the ancient times, is most eloquently expressed by their silence on the issue. As such, most of these traditions have been a rebellion against the caste system and the *Brahminical* hierarchy. Also, these traditions did begin as a 'cry of the oppressed' from the society. *Brahminism* and its support base amongst the upper caste/elite seemingly always reacted against these rebellions, be it the efforts of Shankar in the 6th century or the political onslaught of kings like Pushyamitra Shunga, to establish the kingdom based on a *Brahminical* social order, the goal has been the same -- to re-impose the social hegemony of elite/upper caste and religious hegemony of the *Brahmin* caste.

While Jainism and Buddhism came at the beginning of the agricultural production, centuries ago, Jainism was muted and Buddhism was banished by the *Brahminical* onslaught. Nanak's teachings came just a few centuries ago and laid the basis for a religious community with distinctive history and evolution, separate from the Hindu and Muslim religions but drawing the egalitarian aspects from

both. Nanak denounced orthodox practitioners of Islam as well as Hinduism and placed his emphasis on the vibrant inter-community

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in India. Sikhism laid an important emphasis on *Pangat* (Equality in eating), *Sangat* (Unity of people) and its concepts came closer to atheism.

The establishment of the kingdom around Sikh Gurus led to the cycle of conflict with neighboring Hindu rulers and the Delhi-based Mughal empire and took extreme form with the tenth guru, Guru Govind Singh. Guru Govind stood firm while Aurangzeb was brutally suppressing all the rebellions against the Mughal sultanate. Guru Govind Singh's immediate tussle was with the Raja of Bilaspur, to whom he refused to pay any tribute. This led to the battle in which the Raja of Bilaspur was defeated. Also this brought in the hostility of many of the *rajas* of the hill states towards Guru Govind Singh. He also had allies in the plains -- the most notable amongst them being the *pir* of Sadhura.

Aurangzeb, along with the Hindu *rajas* of the plains, drove Guru Govind away from Anandpur and in the battle, his children were caught and tortured. Later there was an attempt at rapprochement from Aurangzeb's side and he invited Guru Govind to meet him in the Deccan. As Guru was on his way to meet him, Aurangzeb died, but the process of reconciliation with the Mughal sultanate continued and in due course, Guru struck an alliance with Aurangzeb's son Bahadurshah Jafar.

The distorted interpretation of this historical fact forms the base of 'select historiography', whereby the clash between Mughal sultanate is projected and the one between Hindu *rajas* and Sikhs is suppressed. The conflict between the kings is given religious coloring for the politics of elite. To suit the hegemonic cultural project of RSS, all the traditions which came up as a rebellion against *Brahminical* Hinduism, against its version of Hinduism, are subsumed in the Grand Hindu Pantheon. Interpretations which hide the true reason for the emergence of those religions are propagated. The real reasons are the one's related to the movement of the oppressed against the social and economic domination of the *Brahmin*-Landlord upper caste alliance, and these are hidden behind the veil of assertive cultural nationalism.

The current opportunism of Akali Dal in allying with the RSS progeny, BJP is making it blind to the real project of the RSS. The severe setback to the Sikh community due the 1984 anti-Sikh pogrom is projected to show the devil in Congress alone. The real role of the RSS in backing up the Indira-Rajiv onslaught on Sikhs, is deliberately underplayed. It is interesting to note that one of the significant articles by a top RSS ideologue, Nanaji Deshmukh, which subtly supports Rajiv's turning the other way, in the face of the post-Indira-assassination-anti-Sikh pogroms, is hardly known. Mr. Deshmukh in a document circulated to the top echelons of political leadership in the wake of the '84 pogroms presents them as the genuine feeling of anger of Hindus against the Sikhs. He presents the whole thing as though the whole Sikh community was supporting the act of the two guards of Mrs. Gandhi and that because of the assassination, they should quietly bear this attack on the innocent Sikhs.

In the same article he blesses the Rajiv regime while blaming the Sikh intellectuals for alienating the Sikhs from the Hindu community (*Moments of Soul Searching* by Nanaji Deshmukh, translated and published in the Hindi journal, *Pratipaksh*, Nov. 25, 1984). Incidentally this weekly journal at the time was published by none other than the erstwhile secular-socialist, George Fernandes, who is currently enjoying the warmth of BJP's lap. The current rollback is no moment of respite for those who are struggling for a democratic-secular society. It is merely an attempt to assuage the feelings of an enraged Sikh community. A leopard can change its spots, but RSS cannot overcome its politics of Hindu *rashtra* in pursuance of which it wants to subjugate other religious streams, which have emerged in the subcontinent. It is a temporary strategy and in a newer version, on a newer occasion the same thing will be asserted. And as always, when confronted, the Parivar can always say, "Our *Sar Sangh Chalaka* has been misquoted ad infinitum." But by now its designs are there for all to see.

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